

WORKING PAPER SERIES

The Overplus Attractor

Self-Asserting Institutional Systems and the Dynamics of Authoritative Constraint

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Central thesis. Institutions that receive authority to declare legitimate constraint, knowledge, credential, rule, standard, or accepted practice often develop incentive structures that reward further authoritative assertion more strongly than synthesis, simplification, maintenance, or retirement. Under these conditions, complexity can become self-reinforcing and converge toward an overplus attractor.

This manuscript presents a conceptual systems analysis intended for further refinement, critique, and empirical development.

Contents

1 Introduction 1

2 Self-Asserting Institutional Systems 2

3 Novelty Reward as a Structural Attractor 2

3.1 Legislative Exemplar 3

3.2 Academic Exemplar 3

4 The Overplus Condition 4

5 A General Dynamical Model 4

6 Charter Drift and Local Optimization 5

7 Legislation and Academia as Parallel Exemplars 6

8 Cross-Domain Extension 7

9 Structural Corrections 7

10 Conclusion 8

Tier Classification 8

Abstract

This paper examines a general class of *self-asserting institutional systems*: institutions whose recognized authority depends upon producing, certifying, interpreting, or enforcing authoritative assertions. Legislative systems and academic systems provide two primary exemplars. Legislative systems generate statutes, regulations, procedures, offices, and enforcement regimes. Academic systems generate papers, credentials, theories, taxonomies, terminologies, metrics, and research programs. In both cases, institutional reward frequently attaches to recognizable novelty more strongly than to simplification, synthesis, repeal, retirement, or maintenance.

The paper proposes the *Overplus Attractor*: a complex-systems tendency in which the production of authoritative assertions becomes self-reinforcing beyond the point of functional utility. The overplus condition does not require malicious intent. It arises when local incentive structures reward visible production while under-rewarding the less visible work of consolidation, correction, and restraint. A simple dynamical model formalizes the relation between novelty reward and simplification pressure. The paper then compares legislative and academic exemplars, extends the analysis to additional institutional domains, and proposes structural counterweights designed to restore functional equilibrium without rejecting institutional authority as such.

Keywords: complex systems; institutional dynamics; bureaucracy; academia; regulatory constraint; credentialing; novelty incentives; overplus attractor; authoritative assertion; governance.

1 Introduction

Modern institutions do not merely coordinate behavior. They define what counts as authorized behavior, recognized knowledge, valid credential, compliant procedure, accepted standard, publishable contribution, and legitimate public action. This authority grants institutions tremendous stabilizing power. It also creates a recurrent structural hazard: the institution can begin rewarding the production of new authoritative assertions more reliably than the improvement, retirement, or simplification of existing assertions.

Legislative systems provide an obvious example. A legislator receives public credit for sponsoring or passing a new law, especially one that bears a recognizable name, addresses a visible crisis, or extends regulatory reach. Repeal, simplification, consolidation, or quiet maintenance often carries less reward and sometimes invites political cost.

Academia provides an equally important parallel. Scholars often receive recognition through new publications, novel terms, new theoretical framings, citation accumulation, grant acquisition, field formation, and credential progression. By contrast, synthesizing existing knowledge, eliminating redundant terminology, proving that a simpler framework suffices, or maintaining a field's conceptual hygiene often receives weaker reward.

The same pattern appears across many authority-producing systems: standards organizations,

professional credentialing bodies, corporate compliance offices, bureaucratic agencies, software ecosystems, policy think tanks, and even internal project-management regimes. Each may begin with a legitimate charter. Each may then drift toward the self-reinforcing production of additional rules, procedures, classifications, frameworks, credentials, or interpretive layers.

This paper names that structural tendency the *Overplus Attractor*. The term *overplus* denotes institutional accumulation beyond functional sufficiency: an excess of authoritative material that persists because the system rewards further production more strongly than simplification.

Claim. The overplus attractor describes a domain-independent institutional dynamic, not merely a defect of legislation. It appears wherever authority-producing systems reward the creation of new recognized assertions more strongly than the reduction, synthesis, or retirement of existing ones.

2 Self-Asserting Institutional Systems

Definition 1 (Self-Asserting Institutional System). *A self-asserting institutional system is an institution that maintains authority by producing, certifying, interpreting, enforcing, or credentialing authoritative assertions within a recognized domain of legitimacy.*

An authoritative assertion can take many forms. In law it may appear as a statute, regulation, rule, directive, opinion, administrative procedure, or enforcement category. In academia it may appear as a publication, theory, credential, taxonomy, peer-reviewed claim, methodological standard, disciplinary boundary, or citation structure. In professional organizations it may appear as a license, standard, continuing-education requirement, credential ladder, or procedural code.

The phrase *self-asserting* does not imply deliberate self-interest by every participant. It describes a structural property: the institution asserts and reasserts its legitimacy through recognized acts of authoritative production. The act of producing recognized material becomes one of the primary signs that the institution remains active, useful, and deserving of resources.

3 Novelty Reward as a Structural Attractor

Many institutions measure productivity through visible additions. The visible addition may count as reform, contribution, discovery, innovation, compliance, modernization, professionalization, or administrative improvement. The recurring form remains structurally similar:

new authorized assertion $\longrightarrow$ recognition $\longrightarrow$ institutional reward $\longrightarrow$ further assertion. (1)

The corrective loop, by contrast, often receives weaker reinforcement:

$$\text{simplification} \longrightarrow \text{reduced visibility} \longrightarrow \text{limited reward} \longrightarrow \text{neglected maintenance.} \quad (2)$$

The asymmetry between Equations (1) and (2) generates the core attractor. The system need not intend self-sabotage. Local reward gradients can still direct the larger institution toward increasing complexity.

3.1 Legislative Exemplar

Legislative institutions reward novelty through several channels:

- sponsorship or passage of new bills;
- association with named or landmark legislation;
- public visibility attached to reform language;
- expansion of offices, enforcement mechanisms, and regulatory categories;
- crisis response through new statutory or administrative instruments.

The under-rewarded activities often include repeal, simplification, consolidation, sunset review, compatibility analysis, and plain-language restructuring. These activities can improve the health of the legal system while generating less symbolic credit for the individuals who perform them.

The result can produce regulatory density: overlapping rules, cross-references, exceptions, conflicting interpretations, compliance costs, and institutional dependence upon further interpretive machinery.

3.2 Academic Exemplar

Academic institutions reward novelty through a different surface vocabulary but a structurally similar incentive pattern:

- publication counts;
- novel terminology and theoretical framing;
- citation accumulation;
- grant acquisition;
- disciplinary specialization;
- field formation and credential progression.

By contrast, academia often under-rewards work that clarifies, unifies, compresses, or retires unnecessary conceptual machinery. A synthesis that reduces ten overlapping terms to two may contribute more genuine understanding than another minor terminological expansion, yet the latter may travel more easily through existing publication and credential systems.

This does not make novelty intrinsically harmful. Novelty remains necessary for discovery. The overplus hazard appears when novelty becomes the dominant reward signal even where synthesis, replication, correction, or conceptual pruning would better serve the domain.

4 The Overplus Condition

Definition 2 (Overplus Condition). *An institution enters an overplus condition when the stock of authoritative assertions exceeds functional utility and begins generating additional complexity primarily because existing complexity now requires further interpretation, administration, credentialing, or enforcement.*

The overplus condition may manifest through:

- dense cross-referential structures that require specialist navigation;
- proliferating categories that no longer increase explanatory or administrative clarity;
- redundancy disguised as innovation;
- rule systems that require further rules to resolve the burdens created by prior rules;
- credential systems that expand faster than demonstrated competence gains;
- academic literatures whose terminological growth exceeds integrative understanding.

The overplus condition differs from ordinary inefficiency. Inefficiency may arise from poor design or temporary friction. Overplus functions as an attractor because the accumulated material becomes a reason for further institutional production.

5 A General Dynamical Model

Let $A(t)$ denote the stock of authoritative assertions at time t . The variable $A(t)$ includes domain-specific objects such as statutes, regulations, publications, credentials, theories, procedures, standards, categories, and interpretive layers.

Let $N(A)$ represent institutional reward for new authoritative assertion, and let $S(A)$ represent institutional pressure toward synthesis, simplification, repeal, retirement, or consolidation. A minimal conceptual model takes the form

$$\frac{dA}{dt} = \alpha N(A) - \beta S(A), \quad (3)$$

where $\alpha, \beta > 0$ denote the relative institutional sensitivity to novelty reward and simplification pressure.

When

$$\alpha N(A) > \beta S(A), \quad (4)$$

authoritative assertion accumulates. If the inequality persists across a wide range of institutional states, the system tends toward a high-complexity regime. In that regime, the burden of accumulated assertion increases the demand for further interpretation, classification, credentialing, and administration.

Principle 1 (Institutional Overplus Principle). *Self-asserting institutions whose internal reward structures preferentially reward the creation of new authoritative assertions over the reduction, synthesis, maintenance, or retirement of existing assertions tend to accumulate complexity until constrained by external resource limits, legitimacy failure, crisis, or deliberate structural reform.*

Proposition 1 (Attractor Interpretation). *If novelty reward remains institutionally visible while simplification reward remains weak, and if accumulated assertion increases the perceived need for further authoritative assertion, then the system admits an overplus attractor: a self-reinforcing high-complexity regime that can persist even when marginal utility declines.*

Conceptual proof. The system rewards additions more reliably than reductions. Each addition increases the stock $A(t)$. A larger stock increases interpretive and administrative burden, which then creates new occasions for authorized clarification, exception, credentialing, or procedure. These occasions feed back into novelty reward. Unless simplification pressure rises enough to offset that feedback, the trajectory moves toward higher assertion density. The resulting high-density regime persists because the accumulated complexity supplies continuing justification for further institutional activity. $\square$

6 Charter Drift and Local Optimization

Most institutions begin with a charter-level purpose. Legislative systems aim to protect rights, coordinate collective action, and promote public welfare. Academic systems aim to preserve, test, extend, and transmit knowledge. Standards bodies aim to coordinate reliable practice. Professional organizations aim to protect competence and public trust.

The overplus attractor appears when local performance metrics diverge from the global charter. Participants optimize for visible, rewarded outputs: bills passed, articles published, standards issued, credentials awarded, frameworks launched, procedures adopted. These outputs may support the charter at first. Over time, however, the output metric can become a substitute for the charter.

Local metric: recognizable production of authoritative material.

Global charter: improved governance, knowledge, competence, coordination, or public welfare.

Failure mode: the institution optimizes the local metric while claiming continuity with the global charter.

This drift resembles a principal-agent problem, but the agent need not consist of a single person or faction. The agent can be the institution’s own incentive architecture.

7 Legislation and Academia as Parallel Exemplars

The legislative and academic cases illuminate the same structure from different directions.

Table 1: Parallel overplus dynamics in legislation and academia.

Dimension	Legislative System	Academic System
Primary assertion	Law, regulation, rule, administrative category	Paper, theory, term, credential, taxonomy
Rewarded novelty	New bills, named laws, expanded regulatory tools	New publications, theories, fields, grants, citations
Under-rewarded correction	Repeal, consolidation, sunset review, compatibility repair	Replication, synthesis, terminological pruning, conceptual unification
Overplus symptom	Regulatory density and compliance burden	Literature inflation and conceptual fragmentation
Authority mechanism	State sanction and formal enforcement	Credentialing, peer review, citation, institutional prestige
Failure mode	Rule system serves its own expansion	Knowledge system rewards novelty over understanding
Corrective need	Complexity review and repeal incentives	Synthesis credit and conceptual maintenance

This parallel does not collapse law and academia into the same institution. It identifies a shared attractor: both systems can reward authoritative production more reliably than authoritative

restraint.

8 Cross-Domain Extension

The same pattern extends beyond the two primary exemplars.

Table 2: Additional self-asserting institutional domains.

Domain	Rewarded production	Under-rewarded correction
Standards bodies	New standards, revisions, certification categories	Retirement of obsolete standards
Professional organizations	Credentials, continuing requirements, specialties	Competence-based simplification
Corporate bureaucracy	Policies, compliance layers, reporting structures	Consolidation and deletion
Software ecosystems	Frameworks, APIs, dependencies, platforms	Refactoring, maintenance, deprecation
Policy think tanks	New frameworks and white papers	Cross-framework synthesis
Administrative agencies	Guidance, procedures, interpretive memoranda	Plain-language consolidation

These examples suggest that overplus dynamics arise wherever institutional recognition attaches to visible addition while maintenance remains less visible.

9 Structural Corrections

Correcting the overplus attractor does not require hostility toward institutions. The goal is not to abolish legislation, academia, standards, credentialing, or administration. The goal is to bring the reward structure back into alignment with the charter.

Potential corrections include:

1. **Reward simplification.** Give public and institutional credit for successful repeal, synthesis, consolidation, replication, and conceptual pruning.
2. **Require periodic zero-based review.** Treat accumulated assertion as something requiring continuing justification rather than permanent inheritance.
3. **Adopt sunset defaults.** Require explicit renewal for selected rules, programs, standards, categories, or requirements.
4. **Create complexity budgets.** Permit new authoritative assertion only with corresponding retirement, consolidation, or demonstrated net utility.

5. **Recognize synthesis as original contribution.** In academic systems, reward integrative work as genuine intellectual production rather than secondary commentary.
6. **Publish maintenance metrics.** Track deletions, consolidations, replications, simplifications, and deprecated categories alongside additions.

A healthy institution needs both generative and corrective intelligence. Innovation without pruning creates overgrowth. Pruning without innovation creates stagnation. Institutional equilibrium requires both.

10 Conclusion

The Overplus Attractor names a recurring tendency of self-asserting institutional systems: the production of authoritative assertion can become self-reinforcing when novelty receives greater reward than synthesis, simplification, or retirement. The legislative case reveals the dynamic through regulatory accumulation. The academic case reveals the same structure through publication pressure, credential incentives, terminological proliferation, and the under-rewarding of synthesis.

The central issue does not lie in authority itself. Institutions need legitimate authority to coordinate action, preserve knowledge, certify competence, and stabilize public life. The risk appears when the institution begins treating additional assertion as the primary sign of vitality. At that point, the machinery of legitimacy can drift away from its charter and toward its own continuation.

Recognizing overplus as an attractor rather than a mere error allows better diagnosis. The remedy requires institutional counterweights: reward maintenance, credit simplification, privilege synthesis, and periodically test whether accumulated authoritative structures still serve the purposes that justified them.

Tier Classification

Tier II: Structural systems analysis.

Tier III: Interpretive institutional design proposal.

The model presented here functions as a conceptual framework. It warrants further empirical testing across legislative, academic, bureaucratic, professional, and technological domains.